

bedroom as their bedroom, even if it's been your sewing room for decades.

Sell your home. And don't just move to a smaller house that'll still require a constant outpouring of cash. You're getting older. You can't climb ladders to clean the eaves, and you can't shovel snow forever. And you'll still be paying taxes that'll only go up. Your goal is to reduce consumption and become more self-sufficient, not less. So get an apartment or a condo—something you buy outright, so that your only output is the monthly fee. Or you might consider something you can rent for a long time. Here are some things to consider before selling the family home.

Long before you sell, figure out exactly where you'll live and what you can afford. It's nice to buy near the kids, but do so only if you can afford to live there. Otherwise, the onus is on them to visit you. If you're healthy and like traveling, you might consider another country, such as Costa Rica or Mexico, where your money will stretch further and your kids might not mind visiting.

If you have debt, sell as much stuff as you can before you downsize. Your antique hutch that's worth a fortune, your silver collection, even if it holds sentimental value. Liquidate everything you can. Now's not the time to cry over that grandfather clock. It's time to be pragmatic.

If selling the home will generate a windfall, consider this plan. We have friends who sold their big family home and made a fortune. Some of the proceeds were meant to go to the kids as part of their inheritance. But instead of giving them the cash, the couple bought themselves a nice one-bedroom condo and a couple of studio apartments in the same building for their grown children. Now they're all still living under the same roof, the kids can visit often, but they have their own place to go to, to pay for, and to keep up. I like this plan. You don't have to buy your kids a place outright—a down payment is generous enough—but it's a smart way to liquidate a big asset and pass on a bit of wealth, if that's what you're intending to do anyway.

Invest money from the liquidation wisely and conservatively. Now's not the time to play the markets and take big risks with your portfolio. I strongly advise you to hire a financial advisor, either fee-